



REQUEST FOR PROPOSALS

Workforce Innovation and Opportunity Act Title I
Career Services for Adults and Dislocated
Workers and Jobs First Employment Services
Case Management

July 1, 2025 – June 30, 2026

Issue Date: November 4, 2024

Deadline for Submission: January 17, 2025

Northwest Regional Workforce Investment Board
www.nrwib.org

INTRODUCTION

The Northwest Regional Workforce Investment Board, Inc. (NRWIB) is the administrative entity that oversees and administers Workforce Innovation and Opportunity Act (WIOA) and CT-DOL funded programs in the Northwest Region Workforce Development Area (WDA). The NRWIB together with other workforce partners in our region promotes effective delivery of workforce development services throughout the Region

The NRWIB workforce development area consists of forty-one municipalities. They are: Barkhamsted, Bethlehem, Bethel, Bridgewater, Brookfield, Canaan, Cheshire, Colebrook, Cornwall, Danbury, Goshen, Hartland, Harwinton, Kent, Litchfield, Middlebury, Morris, Newtown, New Fairfield, New Milford, New Hartford, Naugatuck, Norfolk, North Canaan, Prospect, Redding, Ridgefield, Roxbury, Salisbury, Sharon, Sherman, Southbury, Thomaston, Torrington, Warren, Washington, Waterbury, Watertown, Winchester, Winsted, Wolcott, and Woodbury.

This is a Request for Proposals (RFP) for the management and delivery of the WIOA Title I career services for adults and dislocated workers in the one-stop centers throughout the region. The proposer selected will be responsible for 1) the delivery of career services to the general population in concert with Connecticut Department of Labor (CT DOL) staff funded through the Wagner Peyser Act and 2) to WIOA eligible adults and dislocated workers, and 3) the delivery of Jobs First Employment Services (JFES) to welfare recipients required to meet work activity requirements under the Personal Responsibility and Work Opportunity Reconciliation Act of 1996 (PRWOR). In addition, the NRWIB receives discretionary grants from time to time that require employment services for special populations. Funds may be added to the selected proposer's contract so that the selected proposer may provide employment services to individuals targeted by those grants.

The NRWIB is seeking a single proposer to provide these services.

To assist proposers in responding to this RFP, demographics and job and labor market information for the NRWIB workforce area are available for review at: www.nrwib.org, click on NRWIB WIOA Local Plan 2024-2028.

This RFP is electronic and can be downloaded from the NRWIB website www.nrwib.org. Paper copies will not be available.

This is not an open RFP, therefore, responses must be received by 4:00 p.m. on January 17, 2025, after which time NRWIB will not accept additional proposals. NRWIB will maintain all proposals on file for three (3) years in the event negotiations with the selected proposer cannot be finalized, additional funds become available through the WIOA, or the selected proposer is not able to perform contracted activities. Proposer(s) who do not submit proposal responses will not be considered for funding after the proposal deadline for submission. Proposers must score a minimum of 70% to be considered for funding.

A Proposers' Conference to review the RFP and process is scheduled for November 13, 2024 at 12:00 p.m. The meeting will be fully virtual. Please contact Jeff Lynes at Jeffrey.lynes@nrwib.org for an invitation.

Questions regarding this RFP should be submitted in writing to the link provided on the NRWIB website. Questions will be accepted until December 13, 2024 answers will be posted on the website. Phone call inquiries will not be accepted. Answers to questions asked at the Proposers' Conference will be made public on the NRWIB website, www.nrwib.org.

Notification of Intent to Apply

Please submit the attached Notification of Intent to Apply by December 20, 2024 found in *Attachment 1*. The form may be faxed or emailed to Jeff Lynes at 203-573-8951 or Jeffrey.lynes@nrwib.org. ***This is an RFP requirement failure to notify the NRWIB through the Notice of Intent to Apply will disqualify your organization.***

We thank you in advance for your time and effort and look forward to reading and reviewing your proposal(s) due by 4:00 pm on January 17, 2025.

AI Summary and Authorization Pilot

To streamline the proposal review process, NRWIB will employ artificial intelligence (AI) technology to create summaries of each proposal submission. These summaries will assist the evaluation committee in its review and scoring. Each proposer must review the AI-generated summary for accuracy and sign a confirmation form authorizing NRWIB to pilot the use of the summary as part of the evaluation. Please see Appendix A: AI-Generated Summary Authorization Form.

SECTION I: DESCRIPTION OF REQUESTED CAREER SERVICES

WIOA requires that one stop centers be the front door for accessing career services under WIOA or from related federal and local workforce funding streams represented by other one-stop partners co-located or in the region. Services are provided to job seekers needing training and /or job placement as well as to employers looking for employees, employee training, information about workforce services and labor market information. There is one full service comprehensive one-stop centers in the NRWIB workforce area and 2 affiliate/satellite one stop centers.

The NRWIB is interested in fostering an integrated approach to assisting individuals and employers while also avoiding duplication of services among the one stop legislative partners. This will result in better more effective services to the client and an expanded capacity within the community to increase the number of individuals being served.

The NRWIB is looking for one provider to staff and provide WIOA Title I career services in the full service comprehensive one stop center, and to staff and provide services or access to WIOA and one-stop partner services in the affiliate or satellite centers as described in WIOA and the regulations promulgated there under.

Job seekers enter the one-stop now also referred to as America's Job Centers (AJC) through the resource room. The selected proposer will be expected to coordinate with CT DOL to maintain and provide labor exchange services through the resource room, before being referred to one stop partner or WIOA individualized services for those meeting WIOA eligibility requirements. CT DOL maintains CT HIRES, the job bank, provides job referral services and solicits employers to list jobs. All direct placement, replacement and assistance in placing individuals following completion of training is coordinated with CT DOL staff assigned to the one-stop. Proposer's staff will be expected to assist with these functions and augments capacity already available in the one stop centers.

Proposer will be responsible for providing information in formats that are usable by and understandable to one-stop center customers.

Individuals with one or more of the WIOA barriers which interfere with their ability to be employed and self-sufficient or who are dislocated workers or are WIOA eligible out of school youth receive individualized services and may already be utilizing a variety of social and human services in addition to those available through WIOA. Case worker / counselors (Career Navigators) are responsible for coordinating the services needed with those already being delivered.

The proposer selected will be responsible for case management and counseling during participation in WIOA and JFES funded activities and through the 12-month follow up/ retention period in unsubsidized employment.

While there is no mandated order in the delivery of services, services available under WIOA Title I should be appropriate to meet the needs of the job seeker including JFES recipients and employers.

AI-Generated Summary Process- Pilot

As part of the proposal submission process, proposers are asked to authorize the NRWIB's pilot use of AI-generated summaries of their submissions. NRWIB will provide each proposer with the AI summary to review for accuracy. Proposers must sign off on the summary's accuracy, allowing NRWIB to pilot what is intended to be a more efficient and thorough evaluation process.

Required Career Services: WIOA and JFES

Listed below are the career services the NRWIB requires be delivered by the selected proposer through the AJC One-Stop Comprehensive and Affiliate/Satellite Centers. Many of the services are informational or self-help or are available through technology.

General information through orientations to services available through the one-stop system for the general public
An orientation on the requirements for participation in WIOA adult, dislocated worker and youth programs
A JFES orientation which provides information requirements of the JFES programs. incorporating the importance and benefit of gainful employment and explaining job search limitations and work activity requirements.
General labor exchange services to the universal population and employers in coordination with the Connecticut Department of Labor (CT DOL) as well as
The provision of local, regional and national labor market information to job seekers and employers including job vacancy listings
The provision of employment statistics for the NRWIB Labor Market
The provision of the occupations in demand lists to job seekers, (these are provided by the state)
Information relating to local occupations in demand and the earnings, skill requirements, and opportunities for advancement for such occupations
Information and assistance filing unemployment compensation claims
Outreach, intake, including worker profiling, and the coordination of outreach with the one stop partners, recruitment, and determination of WIOA eligibility of adults and dislocated workers
Referral of individuals to other one-stop partners as appropriate
Referral to English language acquisition and integrated education and training programs
Initial assessment of skill levels, including literacy, numeracy, and English language proficiency, aptitudes, abilities including skills gaps, and supportive service needs
To make performance and cost information available as it applies to training providers including youth providers, adult education providers, post-secondary career and technical education and vocational education providers available in the community. (Information will be provided by the NRWIB)
Referral of individuals for information regarding the availability of financial aid for education not provided by WIOA
“Work First” services to JFES clients, including but not limited to work registration, career counseling, four weeks of job search, assessment, screening, placement into a work activity, job club, job development, referral to educational activities, job placement and job re-placement.

Job Club /job search activities for Wagner Peyser and WIOA customers in coordination with CT DOL.
Job Development, placement and replacement into unsubsidized employment in coordination with CT DOL for the universal population, WIOA and JFES participants
Access to and the provision of computer based technologies related to workforce activities such as financial literacy, digital literacy and basic skills remediation
Coordination and referral to short-term prevocational services, including development of learning skills, communication skills, interviewing skills, punctuality, personal maintenance skills, and professional conduct, to prepare individuals for unsubsidized employment or training (Provided by CT DOL- subject to funding)
Services to assist WIOA adults , dislocated workers and youth to obtain or retain employment, that may include as appropriate, assessments of individual skill levels and support service needs, interviews and evaluations to identify employment barriers and employment goals, development of an individual employment plan, identifying appropriate employment goals, and the services needed to achieve the employment goals, providing information on eligible training providers and career pathways to attain career objectives
An economic analysis to develop an employment goal targeted toward attainment of self-sufficiency or a livable wage
Development of JFES and WIOA client individual service strategies
Individualized counseling which include elements of employability life skills, job and career counseling as appropriate to the client.
Case management during program participation which include flexible work hours for counselors to suit a working clientele and allow for evening and weekend accessibility between the client and their case manager.
Referral of clients needing assistance beyond the case manager's expertise to other one-stop partners and agencies providing assistance such as but not limited to mental health, substance abuse or domestic violence.
Referrals of eligible and enrolled WIOA participants to occupational skills training and award of an Individual Training Account voucher for training with an eligible training provider
Development of internships and work experiences that are linked to careers for adults, dislocated workers and youth
Referrals of WIOA participants to work based training options such as On the Job and Customized training
Data entry into the state's data base for WIOA and JFES participants to record all services provided.
Post-services employment follow-up case management, counseling, advocacy and replacement into unsubsidized employment for WIOA and JFES participants throughout the 12-month retention period
Services to employers, including but not limited to assistance with employee recruitment, knowledge of employer incentives, and assistance with employer recruitment.

SECTION II: DESCRIPTION OF REQUESTED CAREER SERVICES

JFES (Welfare) Clients

Welfare applicants must, with some few exceptions dictated by the law, look for work upon application for TANF benefits. Job search activities must be conducted after applicants are approved for cash assistance. During the initial 4 – 6 weeks JFES clients participate in job search and must be assessed. If the individual is able to secure a job during job search, they are to be referred for transitional services.

WIOA Dislocated Workers

Dislocated workers means an individual whom fits one of the 10 categories of dislocated worker described in WIOA section 3 paragraph 15.

WIOA Adults

These are individuals who are 18 or older and who have one of the barriers listed in WIOA section 3 paragraph 24, or who is determined to be low income based on the 2016 Federal Poverty Levels(FPL's) and the Lower Living Standard Income Levels (LLSIL's) under CT DOL AP16-05.

WIOA Youth- Youth Providers will be secured via a separate RFP

These are individuals who are out of school and in school and meet the eligibility criteria as described in WIOA 129 (a)(1)(B)

SECTION III: DESCRIPTION OF REQUESTED CAREER SERVICES

It is expected that approximately 100 WIOA eligible adults, 125 dislocated workers will be referred to training and/or OJT, Work-Based Learning Experience. Allocations are dependent on federal allocations, dollars will be available for ITA's, On the Job Training (OJT), adult work experience, customized training services and such other services as are considered training under WIOA section 134. Youth program vendors (both in-school and out-of-school) will be competitively procured and eligible youth will be referred by the Career Services provider.

These funds will not be a part of proposer's budget, NRWIB will pay the training providers. The contract entered into will hold the proposer liable for funds obligated in excess of the amount available for this activity. Recording/reporting the obligation of funds is considered a component of timely data entry.

NRWIB maintains the Eligible Training Provider List (ETPL) and participants may be referred to any course of training on the ETPL. Proposer is expected to hire staff to market and develop OJT, Customized Training and Work Experience opportunities.

SECTION IV: DESCRIPTION OF REQUESTED CAREER SERVICES

Support services may be made available to eligible WIOA individuals who have been enrolled in a WIOA funded activity to the extent they are not available from other sources within the

community. It is anticipated that economically disadvantaged individuals and/ or dislocated workers may need transportation services and possibly childcare while in job search or when participating in other WIOA funded activities. Proposer will be responsible for providing access to support services in accordance with the NRWIB support service policies and will be assigned a budget amount for the provision of support services. Individuals needing additional services or services not offered by the NRWIB must be referred to other agencies in the community offering needed support services.

SECTION V: DESCRIPTION OF REQUESTED CAREER SERVICES

Proposer will be expected to provide business services which includes:

- Outreach to and recruiting businesses that may benefit from the services of the One Stop system;
- Maintaining a database of business customers who participate in job fairs and other employer services;
- Coordinating job fairs and hiring events;
- Outreach and promoting on-the-job training contracts, as appropriate, for job-seeker and employer customers;
- Appropriate recruitment referrals from WIOA and JFES to fill job openings identified within sector or performance-based business services programs;
- Develop and maintain a system for sharing job postings among staff

SECTION VI: ONE STOP LOCATIONS

The NRWIB AJC one-stop comprehensive center is located at 249 Thomaston Avenue, Waterbury, CT 06702. The NRWIB satellite AJC one-stop centers are located at 62 Commercial Boulevard, Torrington, CT and 185 Main Street, Danbury, CT respectively.

The leases for the centers are held by the NRWIB.

SECTION VII: FUNDING

Approximately \$2,350,000.00 is available for these case management services. This amount includes salaries and fringes for staff proposed but does not include facilities rental which shall be paid for by the NRWIB.

Approximately \$ 1,600,000 is available to serve WIOA adults and dislocated workers.

Approximately \$ 750,000 is available to serve JFES recipients

The NRWIB reserves the right to adjust these amounts when determining the winning proposals as well as during contract negotiations.

SECTION VIII: CONTRACT PERIOD AND CONTRACT PERFORMANCE

Providers who do not substantially meet the US DOL performance standards applicable to the various funding streams as described in the contract document will not be renewed.

THE ADULT PERFORMANCE MEASURES
The % of participants who are in unsubsidized employment during the second quarter after exit from the program
The % of participants who are in unsubsidized employment during the fourth quarter after exit from the program;
Median earnings of participants in unsubsidized employment during the second quarter after exit from the program;
The % of those participants enrolled in an education or training program (excluding OJT and customized training) who attained a recognized postsecondary credential or a <u>secondary school diploma</u> , or its recognized equivalent, during participation in or within 1 year after exit from the program.
The % of participants who, during a program year, are in an education or training program leading to a postsecondary credential or employment and are achieving documented measurable skill gains
Effectiveness in serving employers.- TBD

Performance Measures	Final Goals PY 2024	Final Goals PY 2025
WIOA Title I Adults		
Employment (Second Quarter after Exit)	71.0%	71.5%
Employment (Fourth Quarter after Exit)	69%	69.5%
Median Earnings	\$7,000.00	\$7,200.00
Credential Attainment Rate	70%	70.5%
Measurable Skill Gains	75%	75%
Effectiveness in Serving Employers	Baseline	Baseline
WIOA Title I Dislocated Workers		
Employment (Second Quarter after Exit)	80.5%	81.0%
Employment (Fourth Quarter after Exit)	76.5%	77%
Median Earnings	\$9,700.00	\$9,900.00
Credential Attainment Rate	70%	70.5%
Measurable Skill Gains	71.0%	71.0%
Effectiveness in Serving Employers	Baseline	Baseline
WIOA YOUTH- NOT A PART OF THIS RFP		

****UPDATED 11/13/24**

Here is a table of the JFES performance measures:

Performance Measure	Description	Calculation
Entered Employment	Overall, a minimum of 50% of Participants served by the Contractor shall enter unsubsidized employment.1	The total number of Participants served as of July 1, 2024 who are employed DIVIDED BY the total number of Participants who begin receiving JFES Case Management services during the contract period who are not employed.1
Employment at the Payment Standard	For a minimum of 50% of employed individuals, such employment shall result in a household gross income from earnings being equal to or exceeding the monthly TFA payment standard plus \$90 for a family of three.1	The monthly TFA payment standard plus \$90 for a family of three (3) in DSS Rent Region B. DIVIDED BY The total number of Participants receiving JFES Case Management services who are employed during the contract period.1
Employment Entries at the Federal Poverty Level (FPL)	For a minimum of 25% of the Participants who enter unsubsidized employment, such employment shall result in a household's gross income from earnings being equal to or exceeding the monthly calculation of the annualized FPL for a family of three.2	The total number of Participants with household gross income greater than or equal to the monthly calculation of the annualized FPL for a family of three. DIVIDED BY the total number of Participants receiving JFES Case Management services who are employed during the contract period.2
Employment Retention	A minimum of 60% of Participants in unsubsidized employment and shall retain employment in two (2) consecutive quarters; and a minimum of 40% of Participants in unsubsidized employment and shall retain employment in three (3) consecutive quarters.2	Not specified.
Enrollment in TANF Activities	A minimum of 50% of all families included in the required denominator of the monthly TANF participation rate calculations, as defined by federal regulations shall be enrolled in countable TANF work activities that meet the minimum federal participation requirements.2	Not specified.

PERIOD FOR PERFORMANCE AND CONTRACT PERIOD

Contracts will be written for one year followed by three one year renewable periods. Renewal will be at the option of the NRWIB. Contracts will contain additional clauses related to termination for convenience with the proper notice to provide for contractors not wishing to continue services beyond any one year period. Performance will be measured each year.

PROPOSAL APPLICATION CRITERIA AND INSTRUCTIONS

1. Who May Apply

Proposer(s) may be public or private not-for-profit corporations, local educational agencies, business and/or trade associations, private for profit corporations, community based organizations, labor organizations and governmental units including municipalities. Minority and women owned businesses are encouraged to submit proposals.

Entities must have been in business in the United States for at least two (2) years prior to submission of an application. If proposer(s) is a foreign corporation (not a CT Corporation) they must have a certificate from the CT Secretary of State showing that they have filed the necessary documents to do business in this state.

2. Accessing the RFP Document and Attachments

Interested parties may access the RFP from the website www.nrwib.org. Interested parties are responsible for checking the website for additions, modifications, and questions and answers concerning this RFP. The NRWIB will not contact proposers individually or respond to questions on an individual basis. All questions received will be posted on the website along with the answers.

Proposer(s) must respond to all the questions in this application section of the WIOA Title I Career Services RFP.

3. Number of WIOA Title I Career Services Providers

The NRWIB is seeking a **single provider** for WIOA Title I services for adults, dislocated workers and youth programs as well as for the implementation of any discretionary grants requiring similar services and received during the Agreement period.

Joint, partner, consortium proposals or proposals which subcontract elements of the services will be deemed non responsive.

4. Due Dates– All dates are subject to change by NRWIB

EVENT	DATE/TIME
RFP Issued to the Public	November 4, 2024
Deadline for Submitting Written Questions to NRWIB	December 13, 2024 @ 4:00 p.m.
Proposers' Conference	November 13, 2024 @ 12:00 p.m.
Letter of Intent to Apply	December 20, 2024 @ 4:00 p.m.
Deadline for Proposal Submission	January 17, 2025 @ 4:00 p.m.

- a. Proposals must be submitted on or before 4:00 p.m., January 17, 2025.

Proposals may be sent by US Mail, Courier or hand-delivered.

- b. Mail courier or hand delivered

Northwest Regional Workforce Investment Board, Inc
 249 Thomaston Ave
 Waterbury, CT 06702
ATTN: Jeffrey Lynes

Proposals may not be faxed or sent electronically.

NRWIB shall not be held responsible for proposer's failure to meet responsiveness, date, time and location deadlines due to late delivery or omissions by the U. S. Postal services or other courier or delivery services.

All submissions should be marked: Response to One-Stop WIOA Title I Career Services

5. The RFP Response Package

- a. The RFP Response package consists of the completion of the Proposal Application, ***Attachment 2*** of the RFP package, and all required forms.
- b. All response packages must be single-spaced, single-sided on 8.5" inch x 11" inch paper. Complete all responses in Arial pitch, 12 point type (note that some tables may require smaller fonts). Maintain 1 inch margins.
- c. Number each page of the response sequentially beginning with the Proposer(s) Application for WIOA Title I Career Services Cover Sheet as page one. The page number should be in a footer with the name of the organization submitting the response, and the name of the program proposed. Footers should be printed in an 8

pitch. Tabbed dividers should not be numbered. Page numbers should be consecutive from beginning to end. Proposals are not to be paginated by sections.

- d. Please submit one complete application with original signatures and all attachments and 15 complete copies with all attachments for a total of 16 sets.
- e. All applications are to be submitted in three ring binders and are not to be stapled or clipped. Each copy should be in its own binder. The proposals are to be arranged and tabbed in the order indicated in paragraphs (g) and (h) below and must be presented in the format described in (f) below. This will make it easy for reviewers to read your proposal and for us to make additional copies if needed. **Proposals that are not in loose leaf binders will be returned unread and will not be considered for funding.** NRWIB will not return proposals or binders or exhibits to proposers.

The original Proposal must contain the original signature of the designated agent officially authorized to act as the contractual agent for the organization affixed to each document where a signature is required.

- f. The original and all 15 copies of the Application should be securely sealed and clearly marked on the outside WIOA Title I Career Services, and submitted by “Name of your Agency.” **Proposer(s) must also submit an electronic version of the proposal on a Flash drive in Microsoft Word and the Budget section in Excel.**

g. In writing your response:

- i. Respond to every question asked. Do not omit any questions.
- ii. The RFP is available to you electronically in MS Word. If using the soft copy of the RFP insert your response below each question. If using a paper copy restate the question and type your response immediately following the question.
- iii. All questions and responses should follow the numbers assigned in the request for proposals. Do not renumber the questions. Use the same number that appears in this request for proposals for the question prior to your answers as the rating sheets are keyed to the question numbers. Raters will not be able to find your responses if you change the numbering system.
- iv. **Do not respond to questions by cross referencing to another response.**
- v. If a question asks for a yes or no answer place the yes/no response at the beginning of your answer and provide the narrative information requested on the next line.
- vi. Start your responses to each section on a new page.

- h. Proposal Order of Documents – Please place the proposal component responses in the following order:**

1. Application for Funds_Attachment 2

- a. Completed Application
- b. Organizational Charts
- c. Two Credit References required of non-public institutions
- d. Work Activity Schedule
- e. Staff resumes or position qualifications if staff are not yet hired

2. Budget Forms Attachment 3

3. Required Federal and State Forms Attachment 4

- a. Certificate Regarding Lobbying
- b. Certification Regarding Conflict of Interest
- c. Certification regarding Debarment Suspension
- d. Certification regarding Drug Free Workplace

4. Experience Reference Form Attachment 5

5. Copy of your most recent Audit or Financial Statement

6. Staffing

There are currently staff providing the services requested under this RFP. The selected proposer will be required to hire all the line staff providing the services. HOWEVER the selected proposer will be able to hire their own managers and supervisors. The selected proposer will be required to interview and consider the managers and supervisors in place at the time of the release of this RFP but it will be up to the proposer to determine whether they wish to retain any or all of the existing management staff.

7. Inquiries, Questions and Updates to the Proposal

All updates or modifications to the Proposal Requirements will be posted on the NRWIB website. All questions regarding this RFP should be posted to the NRWIB website. Questions are generally answered within two (2) business days or sooner if possible.

Questions arising at the Proposers' Conference will be posted on NRWIB website.

Questions will be accepted through December 13, 2024. The NRWIB will not respond individually to questions or send out updates on an individual basis. It is the proposer's responsibility to visit the website to access this information.

8. Proposer References

- a. Proposer must submit two (2) references on the forms provided as **Attachment 5 to this RFP** from organizations, not individuals, familiar with proposer's organization and able to comment on proposer's ability to deliver the services proposed.
Attachment 5
- b. References must have done business with Proposer within the immediate past five (5) years. Please print and make two (2) copies of the form and sign the form at the bottom. There must be three (3) original signatures. Return the signed forms with your RFP response. Proposals without signed reference forms will be deemed unresponsive. Proposer may ask their references to fax the references to the NRWIB at 203-573-8951.
- c. Proposer(s) must submit two (2) credit references. Public/governmental entities are not required to submit credit references.

9. Cure Process

NRWIB has established a discretionary cure process to cure minor omissions in submitted proposals within forty eight (48) hours of notification by the NRWIB via email to the proposer's contact named in the application. Failure to provide the requested information within the allotted time shall result in a "fatal flaw." This process is provided by NRWIB as a courtesy, and as such, NRWIB is not responsible for notification of any omissions or errors in any documentation submitted by the applicant agency in response to the RFP.

All applying agencies are solely responsible for contact availability via e-mail during this cure period and failure to receive NRWIB notification of cure issues is not subject to appeal.

Minor inconsistencies or revisions may be addressed during the negotiation process, at the sole and complete discretion of NRWIB.

10. Selection Criteria

- a. All proposals submitted will be evaluated against all other proposals using the rating criteria, which is a part of this RFP package, (Attachment 6) and ranked by the One Stop Committee tasked with the review of all proposals.
- b. Proposals may not be funded at the funding levels requested.

- c. The highest ranking numerical score does not assure a funding recommendation. Other factors which may be considered include, but are not limited to: a risk assessment, past performance, cost, the likelihood of services resulting in self-sufficient employment, relevant experience and qualifications, or financial viability and stability of the agency.
- d. The NRWIB reserves the right, at its sole and complete discretion, to invite proposer(s) to make a presentation to the RFP Review Committee as a step in the selection process. NRWIB also reserves the right, at its discretion, to conduct pre-selection site visits to any organization that is being considered for funding under this solicitation.
- e. Proposals will be reviewed by staff for responsiveness and substance.
- f. Proposer(s) are advised not to contact NRWIB employees, board members or elected officials charged with oversight of these programs during the review process to avoid conflicts, the appearance of conflicts, or undue influence over the process. This could result in the disqualification of the proposal response submitted.

11. Administrative Requirements

- a. Final performance requirements under WIOA have not yet been negotiated with the state. When they are negotiated the contract developed with the selected proposer will be modified to reflect the required performance rates set at 5% above that required by the state.

Contracts written during the renewal periods as a result of this RFP will be subject to negotiation of expected performance for each year the contract is in effect.

- b. In addition to the federal performance measures, performance will also be measured based on compliance, timely data entry, and monitoring findings. Selected providers who do not meet negotiated performance may be subject to cancellation or non-renewal of their agreement at the end of each program year in which performance is not attained.
- c. Proposer(s) must be able to demonstrate the necessary administrative capability and fiscal responsibility needed to operate the program proposed and to meet federal financial accountability requirements. Proposer's organization may be subject to a pre-award review. This may include, but not be limited to, a review of proposer(s) record keeping procedures, management systems, accounting and administrative systems, training facilities, and curriculum.
- d. Any proposer(s), after a pre-award survey that is determined by NRWIB to not have the fiscal capability to manage the grant funds will be required to post a performance bond, or may be rejected as a provider at the discretion of NRWIB. The cost of the bond cannot be charged to the project proposed. NRWIB reserves the right to review budgets to determine the fiscal capacity of the proposer(s) and may deem a proposal non-responsive if proposer(s) cannot demonstrate fiscal capacity through staffing

sufficient to be able to deliver the program proposed and separation of duties sufficient to safeguard the integrity of the funds.

- e. All organizations funded whether public or private, commercial or not-for-profit, receiving at least \$750,000.00 annually through federal grants regardless of the funding source will be required to conduct and submit an annual audit. Funds may not be included in the budget for an annual audit if proposer does not receive at least \$750,000.00 of federal funds annually.
- f. All media advertisements, collateral and printed material used in the promotion of the program, recruitment of participants, and published reports must name NRWIB as the grantor agency and must be approved in advance of publication by the NRWIB Executive Director. The time necessary to obtain the appropriate approvals must be considered when developing materials or other media advertisements.
- g. Insurance Requirements - The proposer(s) agrees to submit to NRWIB prior to the provision of services under this proposal Certificates of Insurance including all endorsements required herein, and to keep such insurance and the Certificates of Insurance with NRWIB during the entire term of the Agreement to be negotiated. All insurance policies required by this Agreement shall declare any deductible or self-insured retention (SIR) in an amount in excess of \$25,000 (\$5,000 for automobile liability), which shall specifically be approved by NRWIB. Proposer shall be responsible for reimbursement of any deductible to the insurer. If the proposer fails to maintain insurance acceptable to NRWIB for the full term of the Agreement, NRWIB may terminate any Agreement.
- i. If the selected proposer(s) is a governmental entity, they may elect to self-insure for the insurance coverage required for this agreement.
- ii. The policy or policies of insurance must be issued by an insurer licensed to do business in the State of Connecticut. If the carrier is a non-admitted carrier in the State of Connecticut, NRWIB retains the right to approve or reject carrier after a review of the company's performance and financial ratings. The policy or policies of insurance maintained by the Contractor shall provide the minimum limits and coverage as applicable to this project as set forth below:

<u>Coverage</u>	<u>Minimum Limits</u>
Commercial General Liability to include a Broad Form Property Damage Endorsement and Contractual Liability	\$1,000,000 combined single limit per occurrence \$2,000,000 Aggregate
Automobile Liability including all owned and non-owned and hired vehicles	\$1,000,000 combined single limit per occurrence
Workers' Compensation	Statutory
Employer's Practices Liability	\$1,000,000 per occurrence
Professional Liability	\$1,000,000 per claims made

Intellectual Property	To cover any patent, copyright or trademark infringement claims including the cost of the defense of any action brought against NRWIB, its governing Boards and Contractor
Fidelity/Crime/Honesty Bond	In the amount of the funds awarded to proposer(s)

iii. Each insurance policy required by this Agreement shall be endorsed to contain the following provisions:

- I. This insurance shall not be changed, canceled, limited in scope of coverage or non-renewed until after thirty (30) days written notice has been given to NRWIB.
- II. If a thirty (30) day notice of cancellation endorsement is not received, the cancellation clause must include language as follows, which edits the pre-printed ACCORD certificate:

SHOULD ANY OF THE ABOVE DESCRIBED POLICIES BE CANCELLED BEFORE THE EXPIRATION DATE THEREOF, THE ISSUING COMPANY WILL MAIL THIRTY (30) DAYS WRITTEN NOTICE TO THE CERTIFICATE HOLDER NAME TO THE LEFT.

- III. All rights of subrogation are hereby waived against the State of Connecticut, its appointed officials, officers and employees, NRWIB, its elective and appointed officials, officers and employees, when acting within the scope of their employment or appointment. (Endorsement must be attached to Certificate of Insurance.)
- iv. With respect to operations of the named insured performed on behalf of NRWIB, are added as additional insured's except for Workers' Compensation/ Employers' Liability and Professional Liability. (Endorsement must be attached to Certificate of Insurance.)
- v. It is agreed that any insurance maintained by NRWIB will apply in excess of, and not contribute with, insurance provided by this policy. (Endorsement must be attached to Certificate of Insurance for the General Liability policy.)
- vi. Any losses shall be payable notwithstanding any act or failure or negligence of NRWIB, or any other person.
- vii. Commercial General Liability policy shall contain a severability of interests' clause.

- viii. Contractor agrees to maintain Professional Liability Insurance, as appropriate, for a period of two (2) years following completion of this Agreement.
- ix. NRWIB shall retain the right at any time to review the coverage, form and amount of the insurance required hereby. If, in the opinion of NRWIB, the insurance provisions in this section do not provide adequate protection for NRWIB, NRWIB may require Proposer to obtain insurance sufficient in coverage, form, and amount to provide adequate protection. NRWIB requirements shall be reasonable and shall be designed to assure protection from and against the kind and extent of risks, which exist at the time a change in insurance is required.
- h. The procuring of such required policy or policies of insurance shall not be construed to limit Proposer's liability hereunder or to fulfill the Indemnification provisions and requirements of the agreement to be entered into as a result of this proposal.
- i. Proposer(s) must agree to cooperate with and provide such information as may be requested by NRWIB for purposes of filing reports with the State and the NRWIB Governing Boards.
- j. This RFP does not commit or obligate NRWIB to pay for any costs incurred in the preparation of a response or in advance of the execution of a contract.
- k. Implementation of this program may not occur prior to the start date of the contract document.
- l. Proposer(s) whose main headquarters are located out of the workforce area and who maintain their books and records outside of the workforce area must specify in their proposal how they will make their books and records accessible to the NRWIB for monitoring and audit purposes. It will not be sufficient to state that NRWIB may visit contractor's site, the records must be available to the NRWIB in its workforce area. Failure to do so may result in the proposal being deemed non-responsive.
- m. Proposer must agree to be trained in the State of Connecticut participant data entry system. Proposer(s) may not include the costs of any custom or proprietary information technology system in their budgets.
- n. NRWIB will not pay for the maintenance of duplicate MIS systems or proprietary assessment systems owned by proposer or a related company such as an affiliate or subsidiary.
- o. In the event of a conflict or ambiguity between the rules, terms, and conditions set forth in the RFP and the statutes, laws, State policies and regulations, the statutes, laws, State policies and regulations shall prevail. NRWIB shall be responsible for making all determinations in this regard.

- p. Proposer(s) will be required to maintain and provide a case file for each participant. The files will be considered NRWIB property and must be turned over to NRWIB at the end of the contract unless other arrangements are made during contract negotiations.
- q. Proposer(s) will assure that all records pertaining to this agreement, including financial, statistical, property, and supporting documentation, shall be retained for a period of six (6) years from the date of: 1) final payment of under this agreement, and 2) when all audits and litigation are complete and resolved.
- r. Proposer(s) must implement a system for monitoring participant time and attendance in the program.

12. Progress Reports

Proposer(s) will be required to evaluate their progress, and report to the NRWIB on a monthly and annual basis in accordance with a report format to be provided by the NRWIB. Proposer(s) should also be able to report data to include information not yet in the state database for example the number of projected exits or number of projected entries into training.

13. The Agreement Type and Budget

- a. All contracts negotiated as a result of this RFP will be cost reimbursement. This is a contract format wherein all allowable costs detailed in the budget attached to the executed contract are reimbursed upon submission of documentation, which substantiates the expenditures. Allowable means allowable under both the grant funding stream supporting the contract expenditures and the executed contract.
- b. Initial contracts will be written for the program year beginning July 1, 2025, and subsequent renewals may be written for three (3) one (1) year periods beginning July 1st following the first year based upon performance. Additionally, if provider is meeting performance, NRWIB may renew the contract for a second four year term. Renewal will be at the option of the NRWIB Governing Boards. Contracts will contain additional clauses related to termination for convenience with the proper notice to provide for contractors not wishing to continue services beyond any one-year period. Performance will be measured each year.
- c. Proposers must complete the budget section of the proposal using the forms provided for in this package. RFP responses, which do not include the budget forms or which include non-conforming budget worksheets will be deemed non-responsive. The Budget is part of the RFP response and can be downloaded from the NRWIB website at www.nrwib.org as **Attachment 3**. Paper copies will not be available.
- d. All costs, including profit if applicable, salaries and merit increases, are subject to negotiation as a part of the contracting process. NRWIB will compare salaries and other

costs proposed with costs and salaries for similar positions and responsibilities its workforce area in arriving at reasonable negotiated costs. The federal government has imposed salary caps based upon the federal executive level II position levels. Salaries reimbursed or partially reimbursed under contracts funded as a result of this RFP may not exceed the federal salary cap.

- e. Travel outside of the NRWIB workforce development area must be described and justified in the proposal and included in the budget along with detail regarding the need for the travel, the number of persons who will be traveling, and the length of the stay. NRWIB shall determine the reasonableness of the travel during negotiations. All in and out of workforce area travel will be subject to NRWIB mileage rates, travel rules, and procedures unless the proposer's policies and procedures have been reviewed and approved by NRWIB.
- f. No equipment purchases are allowed. Leasing arrangements for property or staff must be competitively procured and approved during negotiation of the contract.
- g. Lease agreements may not be from proposer or proposer's organization or from a subsidiary, or related company or corporation unless they are leased to the general public at the same price as offered under this RFP.

14. Cost Parameters

- a. It is a policy of NRWIB not to provide advance payments. Proposals seeking advances will be considered non-responsive and will not be reviewed or rated. If a Proposer approved for funding later identifies the need for an advance the NRWIB will not be able to proceed to contract execution. Invoices are paid once a month. Proposer(s) must be able to support the cost of the program until they are reimbursed, which typically takes thirty (30) days from the date a clean invoice is submitted. Payment of invoices submitted without the proper documentation may be delayed. NRWIB does not pay defective or incomplete invoices. NRWIB may require that an electronic transfer system be set up for the payment of invoices.
- b. For profit organizations, profit is capped at a rate of ten (10%) percent. **At this time profit is an allowable cost. Profit may be allocated to the cost categories.** Profit is only available as a budget line item for commercial organizations. Total profit paid may not exceed the percentage of profit negotiated, and determined reasonable during contract negotiations. Profit is limited to ten percent (10%) of the contract budget excluding, (1) any funds budgeted for payments to other providers for services not offered by proposer(s), (2) any payments for support services, stipends, work experience, incentives or other participant payments and (3) tuition.
- c. Administrative costs are limited to five percent (5%) based on the executed contract amount.

- d. Supplies and/or materials proposed may not be purchased from proposer(s) or proposer(s) organization or from a subsidiary, or related company or corporation unless they are sold to the general public at the same price as offered under this RFP. Budget items, which are proprietary in nature, must be broken down into a cost reimbursement format.
- e. NRWIB cannot reimburse providers for interest charges associated with the establishment of credit lines. The Office of Management and Budget Circulars applicable to grants prohibit interest payments as follows: “Costs incurred for interest on borrowed capital, temporary use of endowment funds, or the use of the non-profit organization’s own funds however represented are unallowable.”
- f. Any and all work performed or expenses involved in the preparation and submission of proposals shall be borne by the applicant(s). No payment will be made for any efforts or expenses prior to commencement of work as defined by a fully executed contract.

13. Subcontracts

This proposal does not allow for subcontractors.

14. Grievance and Procedures

In the event a proposer(s) wishes to file a grievance in connection with the process, a grievance procedure is available and may be obtained from the NRWIB Administrative Offices. Grievances related to this proposal must be filed in writing within the time frames stated in the NRWIB grievance policy.

15. Conflict of Interest

All applicants must disclose the name of any officer, director or employee who is a member of the NRWIB governing boards or an employee of NRWIB. All applicants must disclose the name of any NRWIB employee who owns, directly or indirectly, any interest in the applicants’ business or any of its branches. Such disclosure must be submitted in a separate letter included with the Application for WIOA Title I Career Service Funds, no later than the proposal deadline.

16. Interference with the Procurement Process

Applicants are hereby advised that, the NRWIB will not award funding to an organization, person, or entity which has hired a person, whether directly or indirectly, or consented to or acquiesced in the employment of a person, whose principal responsibility is to lobby a member of the NRWIB, Inc. or the NRWIB Elected Officials on behalf of the organization, person, or entity which seeks funding from the NRWIB.

Any applicant or lobbyist for an applicant, paid or unpaid, is prohibited from having any private communication concerning any procurement process or any response to a procurement process with any NRWIB staff or rating committee members after the issuance of a funding opportunity and until completion of a contract award. A proposal from any organization will be disqualified if the applicant or a lobbyist for the applicant, paid or unpaid, violates this condition of the procurement process.

17. Compliance

The proposer(s) will fully comply with the applicable requirements of the Acts through which funds are received. It will comply with applicable directives issued by the Connecticut Department of Labor, the Connecticut Department of Social Services as it applies to JFES funds, or other appropriate state department(s). The proposer assures that it will comply with other federal statutes applicable to this agreement.

18. NRWIB Right to Reject or Accept

NRWIB retains the right to accept, modify, reject entirely, or partially reject any and all proposals if, in its judgment, the work proposed will not accomplish the objectives of this project or does not meet all of the requirements of this Request for Proposal.

Appendix A: AI-Generated Summary Authorization Form

Northwest Regional Workforce Investment Board (NRWIB)

Bidder/Organization Name: [Insert Bidder/Organization Name]

Proposal Title: [Insert Proposal Title]

Overview

The Northwest Regional Workforce Investment Board (NRWIB) is piloting the utilization of artificial intelligence (AI) technology to generate summaries of submitted proposals. This summary is intended to assist the NRWIB evaluation committee in their review and scoring process.

Bidders are required to review the AI-generated summary of their submission, confirm its accuracy, and provide authorization for NRWIB to pilot the use of the summary during the evaluation process.

AI-Generated Summary Review

I, the undersigned, acknowledge that I have reviewed the AI-generated summary of my proposal submission and confirm that:

1. The summary accurately represents the content of the original proposal:

☐ Yes

☐ No (Please specify inaccuracies below)

If "No," describe any inaccuracies:

2. I authorize the NRWIB to use the AI-generated summary in the review and scoring process:

☐ Yes

☐ No

Authorization and Acknowledgment

By signing below, I confirm that the information provided is accurate and that I understand the AI-generated summary will be used as a pilot to facilitate the evaluation of my proposal.

Name: [Print Full Name]

Title: [Print Title]

Organization: [Print Organization Name]

Signature: _____

Date: [MM/DD/YYYY]
